

STCC Nurse Telehealth Triage Guidelines

Facts for Medical Call Center Physician Leadership



Purpose

The STCC telehealth triage guidelines:

- Serve as decision-support tools for specially trained telehealth nurses assessing symptoms by phone.
- Help determine safe and appropriate patient dispositions, including: *Call 911, Go to ED now, Urgent Care now, Office Visit (tomorrow/later), or Home Care.*
- Provide standardized and evidence-based care advice and health information for patients triaged to office visit or home care.
- Allow physicians to perform second-level triage for patients referred to the ED, when clinically appropriate

The 2025 Guideline Facts

Adult	464 guidelines; including hospice and women's health
Pediatric	380 guidelines; coverage of newborns, children, and teens
Call Coverage	Over 99% of patient calls
Update Frequency	Annually
Longevity	Over 25 years

Benefits

- Standardize nurse telephone care using evidence-based, expert-reviewed protocols.
- Support safe delegation of after-hours calls to trained nurses.
- Help prevent delayed ED referrals, adverse outcomes, and liability.
- Reduce unnecessary ED visits and associated costs.
- Align with the *Triple Aim*: Improved Health Outcomes, Enhanced Patient Experience, Lower Healthcare Costs.

Evidence-Base Decision Support

The STCC telehealth triage guidelines have been used and clinically validated through usage by over 400 medical call centers and thousands of doctor's offices. For over 25 years the STCC guidelines have been updated, improved, and expanded based on clinical use by healthcare organizations across North America.

The STCC telehealth triage guidelines are used by the top hospitals in the United States. The STCC clinical governance framework includes:

- **Authors:** The senior medical editors are two physicians with over 70 years of combined experience in after-hours triage and guideline authorship.
- **Editorial Team:** The editorial team consists of five physicians and five nurses with experience and expertise in nurse triage.
- **Expert Reviewers:** Over 100 physicians have formally reviewed the STCC guidelines. This includes subspecialists for specialty topics.
- **National Guidelines:** New and updated guidelines from the AAP, AAFP, ACEP, ACOG, AHA, CDC, FDA, ISDA, USPSTF, and other national organizations are incorporated into the STCC guidelines in a timely manner.
- **References:** Medical Literature reviews are performed on a regular basis. See references section in each guideline.
- **Call Center User Feedback:** Annual recommendations and insights from telehealth users lead to essential improvements. Over 40 call centers and their QI programs are part of this review process.



Summary

Schmitt-Thompson Clinical Content (STCC) is a comprehensive resource featuring nearly 800 evidence-based telehealth triage guidelines for both adults and children. STCC quickly integrates new data and national clinical guidelines to address emerging health challenges such as Mpox, COVID-19, and Ebola. The guidelines are developed through rigorous clinical governance processes involving expert clinicians and are continuously updated based on recent medical literature and research findings. These guidelines have demonstrated their effectiveness in improving patient safety and cost-savings in several studies. Trusted by over 400 medical call centers and top hospitals in the United States, STCC's guidelines represent a reliable, evidence-based, tested tool in the rapidly evolving field of telehealth.

STCC Telehealth Triage Guidelines Current Impact on Healthcare

Telehealth encounters (calls) per year	Over 40 million
Telehealth triage nurses	Over 20,000
United States	Over 95% of medical call centers
Canada	8 of 9 provincial call centers